

On the offensive

In an age of shrinking access for journalists, press conferences hold definitive significance. It is the only avenue where teams give insights into their tactics, thinking, and decisions made on the field. For the remainder of the match, journalists are diametrically opposite the players, seated in a press box with their laptops and fancy words, where they can pretend that they still matter. But in the face of social media, with its enveloping reach and superficial gloss, press conferences are just rigmarole. Why reveal the need to hold back your spinners in a game when you can put one of them on an Instagram reel, posing to the latest trending beat, and get a million likes for it?

Punjab Kings, ahead of its game against Royal Challengers Bengaluru, had plenty to answer for: its dip in form, a player under flak for colourism, and a reported division in the dressing room. Most teams would shield their captain or head coach from such questions. It is not ideal, but it is the world we live in now. But Punjab Kings hit a new low when it sent its head physio for the press conference.

Andrew Leipus did the best he could. "It's probably beyond my scope a little bit," he said while beginning to answer a question about his team's strategy to take down the defending champion in Dharamsala. It was a statement he reiterated through the eight-minute-long conference.

Before the game, the team and one of its owners had riposted on social media about the media peddling fake stories about their players. This was perhaps a way to show the media its place by turning the press conference into a mere formality. It was them subtly saying, "We are good on our own." They knew criticism would follow this move, but they also knew there would be no consequences. And hence, a room full of journalists, the Diary among them, were quietly reminded of the little significance they hold.

Abhishek Saini



Much ado about monsoon

It is common for cricket journalists to have a few template questions for press conferences. What is the playing combination going to be like? What is the mood in the dressing room? Will M.S. Dhoni play tomorrow, finally?

In Ahmedabad, ahead of the IPL 2026 match between Gujarat Titans and Sunrisers Hyderabad, the Diary came across a bafflingly strange pre-set query.

In both the pre-match PCs, a local reporter had the same question: "There is a rain forecast for tomorrow. How is your team preparing to deal with that?"

GT assistant coach Vijay Dahiya deflected it by talking about how his team would focus on the controllables, a phrase that should count as Dhoni's biggest (worst?) contribution to Indian cricket.

The reaction from SRH coach Daniel Vettori was bemusement. "It doesn't rain a lot in Ahmedabad, does it?" By the time the reporter had posed the question to Vettori, a Gujarat Cricket Association official

Rising mercury: Ahmedabad is reeling under serious heatwave conditions, with temperatures regularly soaring past 40 degree celsius. AFP

had put himself on fact-checking duty. He whipped out his phone and announced that Google was predicting a zero per cent probability of rain on match day. Normalcy restored. Vettori could only laugh.

Google turned out to be right. Not a speck of rain descended on Ahmedabad that day as the temperature soared to a sizzling 44 degrees. But nobody felt the heat as much as SRH, which was pummelled to an 82-run defeat by GT.

The thrashing, though, did not entirely deflate Vettori. As he walked into the media room for the post-match PC, he chirpily asked, "Where was the rain you guys promised? We could have really used some of it today." Vettori's retort triggered a bout of laughter among the journalists, including the one who posed the original question.

Pranay Rajiv